IELTS Turbo · Week 1 · Sat 31 Oct 2026 · Education

Speaking Part 1: Education

Every answer: Answer + Reason + Example (2 to 4 sentences, about 20 seconds). Do not stop after one sentence, and do not give a speech.

Work or study

1 Do you work or are you a student?
2 What are you studying at the moment?
3 Why did you choose this subject?
4 What is the most difficult part of your studies?

School and teachers

5 Did you enjoy primary school?
6 Who was your favorite teacher, and why?
7 Do you think teachers today are stricter than in the past?
8 Would you like to be a teacher one day?

Learning

9 Do you prefer studying alone or with other people?
10 What is something new you have learned recently?
11 Do you use your phone for studying?
12 How do you usually prepare for an exam?

Good ways to start

To be honest, ... · Actually, ... · I'd say ..., mainly because ... · It depends. If ..., then ..., but ... · For example, ... · That's an interesting question. I've never really thought about it, but ...

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Model answers

Do you prefer studying alone or with other people?
Mostly alone, to be honest. I concentrate much better when it's quiet, so I usually study at home in the evening. That said, before a big exam I sometimes meet a friend, because explaining things to each other shows what we still don't understand.

Who was your favorite teacher, and why?
My English teacher in secondary school. She never just gave us the rules; she made us use the language in games and short debates. I think that's why I started enjoying English instead of being afraid of it.

What is something new you have learned recently?
I've recently learned how to plan an essay in five minutes. Before, I used to start writing straight away and got lost in the middle. Now I write my position and two reasons first, and my essays are much clearer.

Answer · reason · example. Notice the tenses: present simple for habits, present perfect for experience, past simple for finished time.

Grammar of the day: present tenses and modal verbs for opinions

Part 1 is about you now: your habits, your situation and your opinions. Three present tenses and a few modal verbs cover almost every answer.

Form	Use it for	Examples	Signal words
Present simple	habits, routines, facts, likes	*I usually study in the evening.* · *I don't enjoy math.*	always, usually, often, sometimes, rarely, never, every day
Present continuous	now, these days, temporary situations	*At the moment I'm preparing for IELTS.* · *I'm reading a lot these days.*	now, at the moment, currently, these days, this year
Present perfect	experience, and from the past until now	*I've studied English for six years.* · *I've never been to the UK.*	for, since, ever, never, already, recently, so far
Modal verbs for opinions	softer, more polite opinions and advice	*Teachers should give less homework.* · *It might be useful.* · *I'd say …*	should, ought to, might, could, would, can

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Speaking vocabulary: Education

40 words and phrases for talking about education: not too formal, not slang. Phrasal verbs, collocations and natural phrases. Choose the ones that fit you and use them in your answers.

	Word or phrase	Meaning	Say it like this
1	**catch up on (work, lessons)** phrasal verb	do the work you missed	*I was ill for a week, so I had to catch up on my lessons at the weekend.*
2	**fall behind** phrasal verb	make less progress than others	*If you miss classes, it's really easy to fall behind.*
3	**keep up with** phrasal verb	move at the same speed as others	*The course was so fast that I could hardly keep up with it.*
4	**brush up on** phrasal verb	practice again something you knew before	*I need to brush up on my math before the exam.*
5	**pick up (a language, a skill)** phrasal verb	learn without much effort	*I picked up a bit of Turkish from TV series.*
6	**drop out (of school)** phrasal verb	leave before you finish	*A friend of mine dropped out of university to start a business.*
7	**hand in (homework)** phrasal verb	give your work to the teacher	*We had to hand in an essay every Friday.*
8	**look back on** phrasal verb	think about the past	*When I look back on my school days, I mostly remember my friends.*
9	**put off (studying)** phrasal verb	do something later than you should	*I tend to put off revising until the last minute.*
10	**go over (notes)** phrasal verb	check or repeat carefully	*The night before a test I usually go over my notes.*
11	**figure out** phrasal verb	finally understand	*It took me ages to figure out how to plan an essay.*
12	**sign up for (a course)** phrasal verb	join officially	*Last year I signed up for an online programming course.*
13	**get the hang of** idiom	learn how to do something	*Writing Task 1 was hard at first, but I'm getting the hang of it.*
14	**learn something by heart** idiom	memorize it completely	*At school we had to learn poems by heart.*
15	**hit the books** idiom	start studying hard	*Exams are next month, so it's time to hit the books.*
16	**a steep learning curve** idiom	a lot to learn in a short time	*My first year at university was a steep learning curve.*
17	**learn the hard way** idiom	learn from a bad experience	*I learned the hard way that cramming doesn't work.*
18	**pass with flying colors** idiom	pass very easily, with a high score	*She passed her final exams with flying colors.*

19	**do a course** collocation	study on a course	*I'm doing an IELTS preparation course at the moment.*
20	**get good grades** collocation	receive high marks	*I always got good grades in English, but not in physics.*
21	**make progress** collocation	get better	*I've made a lot of progress with my speaking this year.*
22	**take notes** collocation	write down the main points	*I take notes by hand because it helps me remember.*
23	**meet a deadline** collocation	finish on time	*Meeting deadlines was the hardest part of my first job.*
24	**pay attention (to)** collocation	concentrate on	*It's hard to pay attention in a 90-minute lecture.*
25	**a strict teacher** collocation	a teacher with firm rules	*My chemistry teacher was very strict, but fair.*
26	**a supportive environment** collocation	a place where people help you	*Kids learn best in a supportive environment.*
27	**learn from your mistakes** collocation	improve by seeing what went wrong	*My teacher taught me to learn from my mistakes, not to be afraid of them.*
28	**practical skills** collocation	skills you use in real life	*I wish schools taught more practical skills, like managing money.*
29	**a heavy workload** collocation	a lot of work to do	*In my last year of school we had a really heavy workload.*
30	**study on your own** collocation	study alone	*I prefer studying on my own, because I can go at my own pace.*
31	**at your own pace** phrase	as fast or slow as you want	*Online courses let you learn at your own pace.*
32	**to be honest** phrase	used before a real opinion	*To be honest, I wasn't a very good student at primary school.*
33	**it really depends on** phrase	the answer is different in different cases	*It really depends on the subject. I love history, but not math.*
34	**I'm not really into** phrase	I don't like it much	*I'm not really into science subjects.*
35	**it makes a big difference** phrase	it changes things a lot	*A good teacher makes a big difference.*
36	**as far as I remember** phrase	if my memory is correct	*As far as I remember, we had six lessons a day.*
37	**on top of that** linker	also, and even more	*The homework was hard, and on top of that we had tests every week.*
38	**having said that** linker	but (after a positive point)	*I liked my school. Having said that, the classes were too big.*
39	**the thing is** linker	introduces the real reason or problem	*The thing is, most of us study for exams, not for knowledge.*
40	**all in all** linker	to sum up	*All in all, I'd say my school days were happy ones.*

20 more, if he already knows most of the list

A step up: still natural for speaking, but less common.

	Word or phrase	Meaning	Say it like this
41	**cram (for an exam)** phrasal verb	study a lot in a very short time	*I used to cram the night before exams, and I forgot everything a week later.*
42	**swot up on** phrasal verb	study a topic hard (British, informal)	*I'm swotting up on grammar rules this week.*
43	**breeze through** phrasal verb	pass or do something very easily	*She breezed through her finals without much stress.*
44	**scrape through** phrasal verb	only just pass	*I scraped through my physics exam with the minimum score.*
45	**bounce ideas off (someone)** phrasal verb	share ideas to get someone's opinion	*I like studying with a friend so I can bounce ideas off her.*
46	**zone out** phrasal verb	stop paying attention	*In long lectures I sometimes zone out after an hour.*
47	**a quick learner** collocation	someone who learns fast	*I'm a quick learner when the topic is interesting.*
48	**a well-rounded education** collocation	learning many different things, not only exams	*I think a well-rounded education includes sport and art too.*
49	**rote learning** collocation	learning by repeating, without understanding	*Our system relies too much on rote learning.*
50	**hands-on experience** collocation	learning by doing	*Internships give students hands-on experience.*
51	**a gap year** collocation	a year off between school and university	*Some of my friends took a gap year to work and travel.*
52	**peer pressure** collocation	pressure from people your age	*Peer pressure can push students to study harder, or the opposite.*
53	**burn the midnight oil** idiom	work or study late at night	*Before IELTS, I was burning the midnight oil every day.*
54	**know something inside out** idiom	know it completely	*Our teacher knew the textbook inside out.*
55	**a bookworm** idiom	a person who reads a lot	*I was a real bookworm as a child.*
56	**the teacher's pet** idiom	the teacher's favorite student	*Nobody wanted to be called the teacher's pet.*
57	**off the top of my head** phrase	without checking or thinking long	*Off the top of my head, I'd say I had about ten teachers.*
58	**it's not my cup of tea** phrase	I don't really like it	*Chemistry was never really my cup of tea.*
59	**looking back** linker	when I think about the past now	*Looking back, I wish I had read more at school.*
60	**by and large** linker	generally, mostly	*By and large, the teachers at my school were very supportive.*